"Many start smoking to curb anxiety. But **in the gaps that they are without tobacco, they start to have even more anxiety,** triggering a clear dependency pattern"

– DR KEDAR TILWE
Psychologist, Mumbai



had tried quitting 8-10 times before succeeding. The key was to keep them going through counselling that was tailored exclusively for their situation and personality," says Dr Tilwe.

Behaviour therapy has become crucial in the cessation arsenal. "We motivate people, help them identify triggers and find solutions for them through behaviour therapy," says Dr Nimesh Desai, director of the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences in New Delhi. But behaviour therapy itself has changed. "It is a lot more detailed and personalised today," says Dr Mohanty. For example, instead of just asking people to find their triggers for smoking, counsellors ask patients to write down why they smoke, when they smoke and the trigger that makes them reach for a cigarette, and to avoid all such situations going forward.

The most commonly suggested non-medical advice to stop smoking at one time was to chew ice or gum, drink water, or hold a pen in the hand, says Dr Mohanty. Today, cessation research has thrown up a whole gamut of other alternatives—cleaning the house, meditation, going for a run, calling friends or a counsellor, or simply noting down the benefits of quitting in a journal. There is no longer a one-size-fits-all approach to cessation, solutions are customised as per the person and situation. "You pick the distraction or coping mechanism that works for you," says Dr Tilwe. Indeed, a new study looking at 2,500 smokers, and published last month in the *New England Journal of Medicine*, showed that those who had a financial reward to quit had a higher success rate in forsaking tobacco use. Doctors have also observed how in the past few years asking smokers to reward themselves with a holiday, new product or an expensive meal for every month they go without smoking has improved motivation levels.

Post-Covid, a 2022 study by the non-profit Foundation for a Smoke Free World (FSFW) also found that many tobacco users in India turned to newer coping mechanisms such as exercise, yoga and meditation. Many doctors also advise their patients to stay away from social events or find new strategies to cope with stress situations other than turning to tobacco. "One has to delink a person's mind from tobacco, they have to stop seeking it for happiness, temporary relief, peace, or whatever positive emotions they link with it. At the same time, cessation also has to keep a person motivated enough because it is difficult to keep going. But keep going we must," says Dr Tilwe. The allusion to 'positive emotions' touches on a difficult aspect of cessation, because of the way smoking is associated with seductive pop-cultural tropes, and the idea of 'rebellion' and non-conformism.

CASE STUDY

'To quit smoking, I had to help myself in the end'

AALAP DEBOOR, *34*
filmmaker, Mumbai



Deboor tried to quit smoking for the first time in 2017, ten years after he first started smoking. He was in Bengaluru for a month as part of an anti-smoking group. "I thought I had succeeded but then had a relapse a month after quitting. I didn't know how to stop after that." So strong was the addiction that even after he was put on ventilator after an attack of bronchitis, he wasn't able to quit for good. Counselling for tobacco cessation never crossed his mind as he wasn't sure if it would help him.

Ultimately, it was US comedian Allen Carr's book *How to Quit Smoking* that did the trick for Deboor two years ago on April 8. "The lockdown was on and I started listening to the book's audio version every day as I stood in line to buy groceries. I had a lot of support from my wife and family during this time," he recalls. Deboor also realised that seeing someone smoke at the movies was a trigger for him and he began to work towards overcoming it. Today, the urge to smoke is not as strong. "You have to really want to give it up and keep yourself motivated. If there is quality cessation guidance and support available, that of course is added help, but the ultimate urge has to come from within."